

US Public DC Fast-Charging Market Attractiveness for Mid-Size Entrants (2026–2028)

1 Executive Summary

The US public DC fast-charging market presents a cautiously attractive but narrow-margin opportunity for a mid-size entrant over 2026–2028. The expiration of the federal \$7,500 clean-vehicle tax credit in September 2025 materially weakened the demand outlook: BEV market share surged to 12% that month before collapsing below 6% by Q4 2025, and by mid-2026 EV registrations were down 31% year-over-year [1, 2]. The US is tracking at roughly half the pace of the IEA's Stated Policies projection of ~42 million EVs by 2030 [3], meaning the addressable fleet will grow more slowly than many infrastructure business plans assumed.

Despite softer demand, infrastructure deployment is expanding at 30–35% annually, reaching over 75,000 DC fast ports by mid-2026 —yet still 32% below the IEA's 100,000-port target for 2025 [4, 5, 6]. This supply-demand mismatch creates both opportunity and risk: the EVs-per-fast-port ratio has improved from ~112 in 2023 to roughly 96–106 [6, 7], but national utilization hovers at just 16%, barely above the estimated 15% profitability threshold [8, 9]. Demand charges can consume over 90% of electricity costs at low utilization, making rate negotiation and battery storage co-location essential for viable unit economics [10]. Tesla's ~50% port share and sub-\$45,000 per-stall cost advantage remain formidable, though its dominance is eroding and the “other networks” category grew 44% year-over-year, signaling genuine market fragmentation [11, 12].

The most actionable path for a mid-size entrant is a selective, state-focused strategy targeting high-adoption corridors in California and New York, where substantial supplementary funding programs (\$55M+ and \$28.5M+ respectively) offset weakened federal support following the repurposing of \$504 million in NEVI funds in March 2026 [13, 14, 15]. Dual-connector deployment (NACS and CCS1) is non-negotiable for the foreseeable future, adding capital cost but ensuring compatibility across the transitioning vehicle fleet [16, 17].

2 Introduction and Scope

This report assesses the attractiveness of the United States public DC fast-charging market for a mid-size network operator considering entry or expansion during the 2026–2028 period. The analysis is framed as one leg of a three-market comparison (alongside the United Kingdom and EU core), and focuses exclusively on public DC fast charging for passenger cars —excluding home, workplace, fleet depot, bus, and truck charging.

The internal IEA Global EV Data 2024 files provide a critical baseline: approximately 4.8 million EV cars and 43,000 public fast chargers in the US as of 2023, yielding a ratio of roughly 112 EVs per fast charger [3, 6]. The IEA's Stated Policies (STEPS) scenario projects US EV stock reaching approximately 42 million by 2030 with a 55% EV sales share [3]. As this report will demonstrate, actual US market developments through mid-2026 are tracking significantly below these projections, creating a complex risk-reward picture for prospective entrants. Evidence is drawn primarily from AFDC, DOE, FHWA, IEA, EIA, and EPA sources, supplemented by industry trackers, with publication dates prioritized from 2025–2026.

3 Demand: EV Sales Trajectory and Tax-Credit Impact

EV sales share 2024–2026. US battery electric vehicle (BEV) sales reached approximately 1.3 million units in 2024, representing roughly 8% BEV market share —or about 10% when plug-in hybrids (PHEVs) are included [18, 19]. Growth then stalled: full-year 2025 BEV sales totaled approximately 1.26 million units, a gain of only 1.2% year-over-year, while BEV market share actually declined to 7.7% as total light-vehicle sales rose to 16.2 million [20]. The World Resources Institute reported that overall EV sales fell approximately 4% in 2025 [21]. In the first half of 2026, EV sales accounted for roughly 7.1% of US auto sales, with the EIA reporting BEV share at 6% of new light-duty vehicles in Q2 2026 [2, 22].

The Section 30D tax-credit shock. The federal New Clean Vehicle Credit (\$7,500 maximum) and the Qualified Commercial Clean Vehicle Credit both expired on September 30, 2025 [1]. The expiration triggered a dramatic surge-then-collapse pattern: BEV market share hit a record 12% in September 2025 as buyers rushed to claim credits, then fell below 6% in Q4 2025 [1]. By July 2026, EV registrations had dropped 31% year-over-year, with the absence of the federal incentive cited as a primary driver [2]. The IEA's Global EV Outlook 2026 noted that US electric car sales remained relatively stable at just under 10% in 2025 overall, though the end of credits coincided with a notable drop at year-end [23].

Divergence from IEA projections. It is important to flag a significant discrepancy: the IEA STEPS scenario projected a 20% EV sales share for the US by 2025 [3], but actual 2025 share was only 7.7–10% depending on the metric used (BEV-only versus all plug-ins) [20, 23]. This means the US is tracking at roughly half the pace needed

to reach the IEA’s projected stock of approximately 42 million EVs by 2030 [3]. For a charging operator, this gap implies that the addressable EV fleet will grow more slowly than optimistic scenarios suggest, directly affecting station utilization forecasts.

4 Supply: DC Fast-Charging Infrastructure Growth

Despite the demand-side headwinds, DC fast-charging infrastructure has expanded robustly. Starting from the IEA 2023 baseline of approximately 43,000 public fast chargers [3, 24], the US reached 50,428 DC fast-charging ports at 12,279 stations by December 2024—an average of 4.1 ports per station [7]. Growth accelerated through 2025: the year began at roughly 51,000 stalls and ended at approximately 68,000, with US networks adding over 18,000 new DC fast-charging ports during the year, up from about 14,000 added in 2024 [4, 25]. By June 2026, the US exceeded 73,000 DC fast ports across roughly 15,500 sites (averaging about 4.8 ports per location), surpassing 75,000 by late July 2026 [26, 5]. The ICCT documented a 56% increase in DC fast chargers from about 33,000 in mid-2023 to approximately 51,000 by end of 2024 [27], and AFDC quarterly reports indicated DC fast ports were growing 7–9% per quarter through 2023–2024 [28].

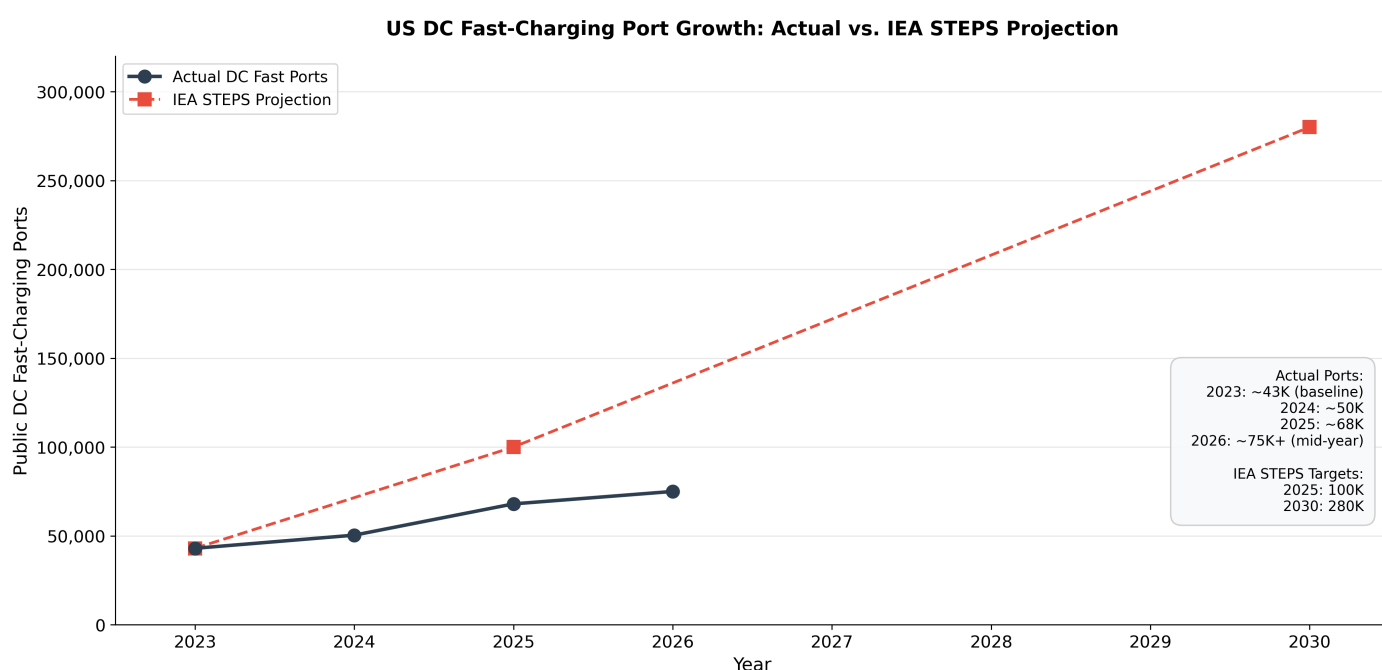


Figure 1: US DC Fast-Charging Port Growth: Actual vs. IEA STEPS Projection

Chart Explanation: This chart compares actual US DC fast-charging port deployment (dark line) against the IEA STEPS projection (red dashed line). The actual trajectory—from 43K ports in 2023 to 75K+ by mid-2026—falls well short of the IEA’s 100K target for 2025 and 280K target for 2030 [7, 4, 5, 6].

EVs-per-fast-port ratio. The ratio of EVs to public DC fast ports has been improving. From the IEA 2023 baseline of approximately 112 EVs per fast charger [3, 6], the ratio declined to an estimated 96–106 by late 2024/2025 as infrastructure deployment outpaced the slower-than-expected growth in EV stock [7]. This improving ratio is a positive signal for drivers but a cautionary one for operators, as it implies that each port serves fewer vehicles—potentially constraining utilization.

Gap versus IEA projections. The IEA STEPS scenario envisioned roughly 100,000 US fast chargers by 2025 [6]; actual deployment reached only about 68,000, a shortfall of approximately 32%. If the 2030 target of 280,000 fast chargers is to be met, annual deployment would need to roughly triple from current rates. This gap represents both a risk (if demand does not materialize to justify the build-out) and an opportunity (if policy and private capital fill the infrastructure deficit).

5 Competitive Landscape and Market Concentration

Network rankings. Tesla’s Supercharger network remains the dominant force in US DC fast charging, though its market share has been declining. As of September 2026, Tesla held 37,995 ports—49.8% of the national total—down from approximately 54.6% in July 2025 [29, 11]. Electrify America ranked second with 5,936 ports (7.8%), followed by EVgo at 5,246 ports (6.9%), ChargePoint at 4,937 ports (6.5%), Red E Charge at 2,141 ports (2.8%), and

IONNA at 1,458 ports (1.9%) [11]. IONNA, the automaker-backed joint venture, deployed roughly 800 ports in its first operational year (2025) and targets 30,000 sites over five years [30, 31].

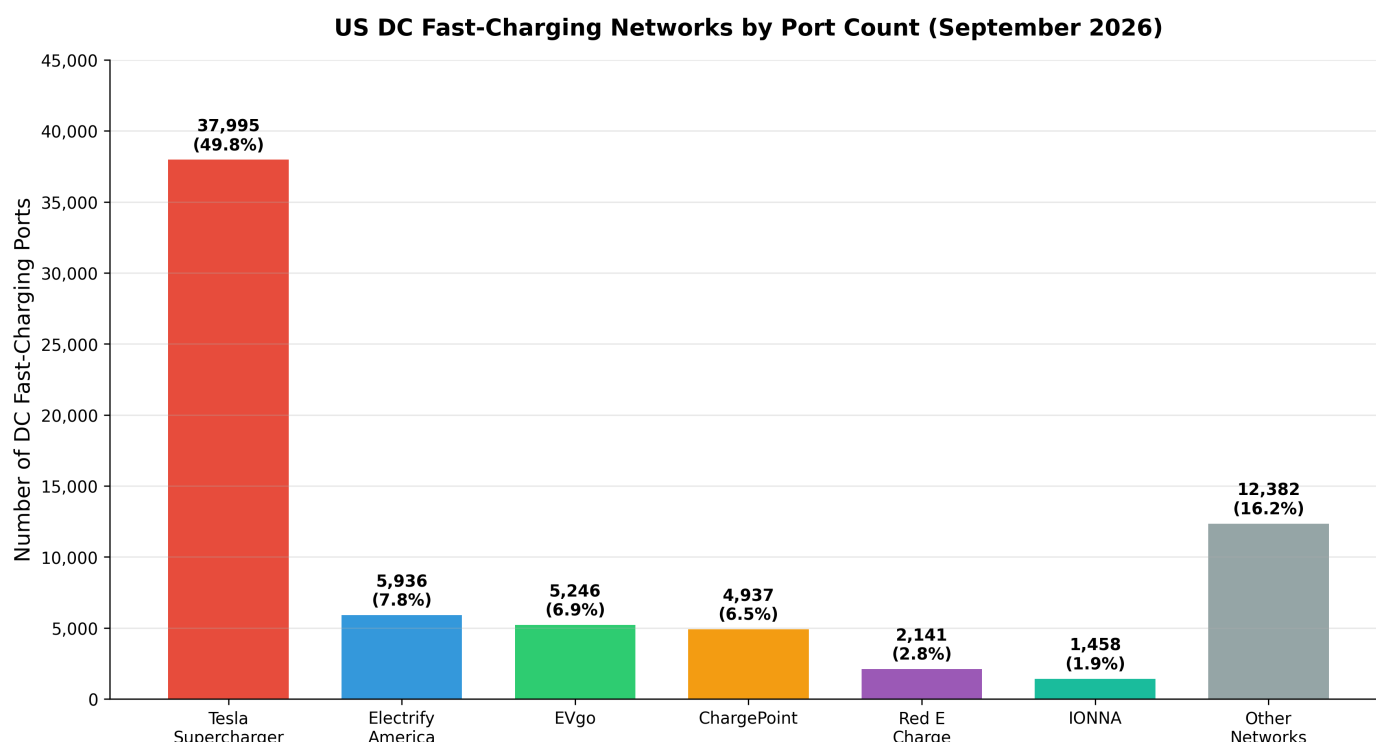


Figure 2: US DC Fast-Charging Networks by Port Count, September 2026

Chart Explanation: This chart shows port counts and market shares for the largest US DC fast-charging networks as of September 2026. Tesla dominates with nearly 50% of all ports, but the “Other Networks” category (16.2%) grew 44% year-over-year, signaling increasing market fragmentation [11].

Market fragmentation signals. The top 10 networks collectively held approximately 84% of the 76,236 total ports as of September 2026, with the remaining 16% belonging to smaller or non-networked operators [11]. Critically, the “Other” category of networks outside the top 10 grew 44% year-over-year, compared to 20% for the top 10 networks [11]. This divergence suggests the market is becoming more accessible to smaller players, a positive signal for a mid-size entrant.

The NACS / SAE J3400 connector transition. Between May 2023 and February 2024, most major automakers—including Ford, GM, Rivian, Volvo, Hyundai, Kia, and others—announced adoption of the NACS (now standardized as SAE J3400) connector for North American EVs beginning with the 2025 model year, replacing CCS1 [32]. As of September 2026, there were over 42,500 public NACS connectors in the US, with non-Tesla networks deploying over 2,700 new NACS connectors in the first eight months of 2026—more than Tesla’s own 2,300 additions in the same period [16]. CCS1 is not being phased out imminently: net CCS1 connector additions were approximately 6,000 in the first eight months of 2026, as many 2026 models still use CCS1 [17]. CHAdeMO, however, is fading, losing roughly 450 connectors in the same period [16]. For new entrants, this transition means that stations must be equipped with both NACS and CCS1 connectors for the foreseeable future, adding hardware cost and complexity.

6 Pricing, Utilization, and Unit Economics

Pricing landscape. DC fast-charging prices in the US vary significantly by network and location. According to Paren’s Leaderboard (August 2026), Tesla and Electrify America average among the highest at approximately \$0.56 per kWh, while IONNA offers the lowest average at roughly \$0.38 per kWh [33]. Tesla charges non-Tesla drivers a 30–35% premium unless they subscribe at \$12.99 per month [34]. Electrify America offers member pricing at approximately \$0.36 per kWh versus \$0.48 for non-members [35]. EVgo and ChargePoint prices range from \$0.31 to \$0.60 or more per kWh, with EVgo using time-of-use pricing and ChargePoint allowing host-set pricing that varies widely by site [36, 37].

Network	Typical Price Range (\$/kWh)	Notes
Tesla Supercharger	\$0.30–\$0.56	Non-Tesla premium ~30–35%; \$12.99/mo membership available [34, 33]
Electrify America	\$0.36–\$0.48	Member vs. non-member pricing [35, 33]
EVgo	\$0.31–\$0.60	Time-of-use pricing varies by location and time of day [36]
ChargePoint	\$0.31–\$0.60+	Host-set pricing; wide variation by site [37]
IONNA	~\$0.38	Lowest average among major networks [33]

Table: Typical DC Fast-Charging Prices by Network (2025–2026)

Utilization signals. National DC fast-charging utilization averaged 16.6% in Q1 2025 [8], dipping slightly to 16.1% by mid-2025 as new charger deployment outpaced EV adoption in some regions [38]. According to Stable Auto, a DC fast-charging station generally needs to dispense energy approximately 15% of the time to reach profitability [9]. This means the national average is hovering just above the breakeven threshold—a precarious position that leaves little margin for error, particularly for new stations that typically take 12–24 months to ramp up utilization.

Demand-charge exposure. The single largest economic challenge for DC fast-charging operators is utility demand charges. According to RMI, demand charges can account for over 90% of a station’s electricity costs at low utilization levels [10]. NEVI-funded stations, which require a minimum of four 150 kW chargers (600 kW aggregate capacity), face amplified demand-charge exposure [39]. Mitigation strategies include EV-specific utility rate designs—states like Massachusetts require utilities to file alternative rate structures that reduce or eliminate demand charges for DCFC [40]—and co-located battery energy storage systems (BESS) to shave peak demand [41]. Tesla maintains a significant cost advantage, reportedly building V3.5 Supercharger stalls at less than \$45,000 per stall, with a target of under \$40,000 for V4, roughly half the cost of competitors [12].

7 Policy: NEVI Program and State Initiatives

NEVI Formula Program status. The Infrastructure Investment and Jobs Act (IIJA) allocated \$7.5 billion over five years (FY2022–FY2026) for the NEVI Formula Program (\$5 billion) and the Charging and Fueling Infrastructure (CFI) Grant Program (\$2.5 billion), with NEVI receiving \$1 billion per fiscal year [42, 43]. However, deployment has been severely delayed: as of May 2025, approximately 84% of NEVI Formula Program funds remained unobligated [44]. By end of 2025, only about 96 NEVI-funded stations had opened, adding close to 500 new ports [45, 46]. In March 2026, \$503.8 million in NEVI funds were repurposed to other highway programs [13], raising questions about the program’s future scale. Revised NEVI guidance issued in August 2025 streamlined applications, provided states more flexibility, and reduced regulatory burden [47].

NEVI station requirements. Stations funded under NEVI along designated Alternative Fuel Corridors must have at least four network-connected DC fast-charging ports capable of simultaneously charging four EVs, with each port delivering a minimum of 150 kW and a station-level minimum of 600 kW aggregate power [48]. Stations must meet a 97% uptime reliability standard per port, display pricing per kWh, and accept contactless payment [48]. The August 2025 revised guidance provides states additional flexibility on connector types, including NACS/J3400 [47].

Major state programs. Several states supplement federal funding with substantial programs of their own. California, which receives the largest NEVI allocation at approximately \$384 million, launched the \$55 million Fast Charge California incentive program in 2025 offering up to 100% of installation costs for EV fast chargers [14], and the CEC approved a \$95.2 million ZEV infrastructure plan for FY2026–2027 [49]. New York allocated \$28.5 million for corridor fast chargers in December 2024 [15] and \$35 million for public-sector EV charging in 2026 [50]. Texas opened its first NEVI station in December 2024 [51].

State	NEVI Allocation	Key Supplementary Programs
California	~\$384M	\$55M Fast Charge California (2025); \$95.2M CEC ZEV plan (FY2026–27) [14, 49]

State	NEVI Allocation	Key Supplementary Programs
New York	~\$175M (5-year)	\$28.5M corridor fast chargers (2024); \$35M public-sector charging (2026) [15, 50]
Texas	~\$110M+	First NEVI station opened Dec 2024; TCEQ DCFC Program [51]

Table: Major State EV Fast-Charging Programs

8 Key Risks and Market Attractiveness Assessment

Demand risk. The expiration of the Section 30D tax credit has materially slowed EV adoption, with BEV share falling from a peak of 12% in September 2025 to roughly 6–7% through mid-2026 [1, 2, 22]. The US is tracking at roughly half the pace of IEA STEPS projections [3], meaning the addressable EV fleet will grow more slowly than many business plans assumed. Without a new federal incentive, demand growth may remain subdued through 2027–2028.

Competitive risk. Tesla’s approximately 50% market share, vertically integrated model, and cost advantage (stalls at less than \$45,000 versus competitors’ significantly higher costs) create a formidable moat [11, 12]. The entry of IONNA, backed by seven major automakers and targeting 30,000 sites, adds another well-capitalized competitor [31]. However, the 44% year-over-year growth in the “Other” network category suggests the market is not foreclosed to smaller players [11].

Financial risk. National utilization at approximately 16% sits just above the estimated 15% profitability threshold [8, 9], and demand charges can consume over 90% of electricity costs at low utilization [10]. New stations face a ramp-up period during which they are likely to operate below breakeven. The dual-connector requirement (NACS plus CCS1) adds to capital expenditure per port.

Policy risk. The repurposing of \$504 million in NEVI funds in March 2026 [13] and the fact that 84% of funds remained unobligated as of May 2025 [44] signal uncertainty about the scale and pace of federal support. While revised guidance has streamlined the process [47], a mid-size entrant cannot rely on NEVI as a primary funding source for its 2026–2028 expansion.

Opportunity signals. Despite these risks, several factors support market entry. Infrastructure deployment is growing at roughly 30–35% annually [4, 25], the EVs-per-fast-port ratio is improving [7], and market fragmentation is increasing as Tesla’s share declines below 50% [11]. State-level programs in California, New York, and Texas provide meaningful supplementary funding [14, 49, 15]. The NACS standardization simplifies the long-term connector landscape, even if dual-connector costs persist in the near term [32, 16].

Overall assessment. The US DC fast-charging market in 2026–2028 presents a mixed but cautiously attractive opportunity for a mid-size entrant. The demand outlook has weakened materially following the tax-credit expiration, and the competitive landscape is dominated by Tesla’s scale and cost advantages. However, the structural need for charging infrastructure remains enormous —actual deployment lags IEA projections by roughly 32% —and the market is demonstrably fragmenting in ways that create space for new operators. A mid-size entrant should pursue a selective, state-focused strategy: target high-EV-adoption corridors in states with strong supplementary funding (California, New York), negotiate favorable utility rate structures to mitigate demand-charge exposure, and plan for dual-connector (NACS plus CCS1) deployment. The window is open, but the margin for error is thin.

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